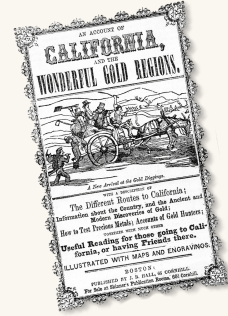


BEFORE

THE GOLD RUSH

California achieved statehood in 1850, while Utah and New Mexico were absorbed into the United States as territories. These thinly populated areas took on **economic importance after the discovery of their precious metals**. The **California Gold Rush** had begun in 1848. The discovery of silver and gold at the Comstock Lode in western Utah and at sites in western Kansas in the late 1850s was followed by the organization of these areas into the territories of **Nevada and Colorado** in early 1861.



DIVIDING UP AMERICA

The creation of **new states and territories** was a fraught political issue, affecting the balance between “slave” and “free” states (see [Slavery Divides the Country](#)).

In 1861, **Texas was among the original states that formed the Confederacy**, while California, New Mexico, Utah, Nevada, and Colorado all stayed within the Union.

CALIFORNIA ADVERTISEMENT

The first Confederate thrust westward from Texas took place early in the war on the initiative of an aggressive battalion commander, Lieutenant Colonel John R. Baylor. A one-time politician and Indian fighter, Baylor was sent with a 250-strong detachment of mounted Texan volunteers to seize undefended forts along the state's western border with New Mexico. He interpreted his orders as license to enter New Mexico on the grounds of preempting a potential Union counterattack. Deciding that a U.S. Army garrison at Fort Fillmore constituted a threat, Baylor set out to attack it on July 23, 1861. The garrison commander, Major Isaac Lynde, left the fort with his troops to confront Baylor. On July 25 Baylor's Texans and their allies repulsed Union infantry and cavalry assaults, driving them back to Fort Fillmore. During the night the Union commander Lynde led a withdrawal from Fort Fillmore but was pursued to San Augustin Springs where he and his men all surrendered. Baylor declared the south of New Mexico the Confederate Arizona Territory.

Baylor had scant resources to fight hostile Apaches and resist a Northern counterattack. But when another Southern force was sent into Confederate Arizona in early 1862, it was dispatched with offensive rather than defensive intentions.